

ISS 4931: Big Problems in PPEL

Challenges of the Twentieth Century

I. General Information

Class Meetings

- Fall 2026
- Meeting days and times: MWF 9:35–10:25 AM
- Room: TBD
- Credits: 3

Instructor

- Professor Mark Koyama
- Office: TBD
- Office Hours: By request
- Email: mkoyama@ufl.edu

Course Description

This course examines a major contemporary problem at the intersection of Philosophy, Politics, Economics, and Law (PPEL).

Topic: The twentieth century saw the greatest transformation in human material welfare in history. Global GDP per capita rose more than fivefold; life expectancy nearly doubled; and literacy became the norm rather than the exception. Yet this same century also witnessed two world wars, genocides, totalitarian regimes, famines, and persistent poverty across much of the globe. Why did some societies achieve sustained prosperity while others stagnated or collapsed into violence? And what roles did economic ideas, political institutions, and ideology play in shaping these divergent outcomes?

This course uses the economic history of the twentieth century to explore these questions. We trace how each era's dominant economic framework—from the classical liberalism of the first age of globalization, through socialism and Keynesianism, to the “neoliberal” order of the late twentieth century—arose as a response to the perceived failures of its predecessor. Students will engage with primary sources, economic data, and recent scholarship to understand the interplay between markets and states, the distributional consequences of economic policy, and the recurring tension between economic efficiency and political legitimacy. The course

culminates with an examination of globalization, rising inequality, and the contemporary backlash against the liberal economic order—problems whose historical roots run through every topic we study.

Required Readings and Works

- Mark Koyama and Jared Rubin, *How the World Became Rich: The Historical Origins of Economic Growth* (Cambridge: Polity Press, 2022). ISBN: 978-1-509-54020-9.
- J. Bradford DeLong, *Slouching Towards Utopia: An Economic History of the Twentieth Century* (New York: Basic Books, 2022). ISBN: 978-0-465-01959-7.
- All other required readings will be made available as PDFs on Canvas. Additional readings may be added at instructor's discretion.

Course Objectives

By the end of this course, students will be able to:

- Analyze how major economic ideas—classical liberalism, socialism, Keynesianism, monetarism, neoliberalism—shaped political institutions and policy.
- Evaluate the distributional consequences of economic policies, including trade, inflation, and welfare state expansion, using historical evidence.
- Read and critically assess research papers in economics and economic history.
- Employ core concepts from microeconomics, macroeconomics, and econometrics to interpret historical episodes.
- Construct well-reasoned analytical arguments in both written and oral form, drawing on primary sources and quantitative evidence.

II. Graded Work

Active Participation and Attendance: 15% consisting of:

Participation (10%): Students are expected to come to class having completed the assigned readings and prepared to discuss them. High-quality participation involves asking thoughtful questions, responding to peers, and connecting readings to broader course themes.

Class Attendance (5%): Students may miss up to three classes without penalty. Beginning with the fourth unexcused absence, the final course grade will be reduced by two-thirds of a letter grade for each additional unexcused absence (e.g., A to B+, B+ to B-).

Discussion and Presentation Assignments: 15%

Students will deliver 5–7 minute oral presentations applying historical material to contemporary issues. Presentation assignments will be distributed in advance.

Midterm Examination: 30%

An in-class written examination consisting of essay questions. The midterm will cover all material from Weeks 1–7.

Final Exam 40%

An in-class written examination consisting of essay questions. The final will be comprehensive.

III. Annotated Weekly Schedule

*This is a reading-intensive seminar. Readings marked with * are primary sources that must be completed before class. Readings are subject to change and will be updated on Canvas.*

Part I: The Rise and Crisis of the Global Economy

Week 1 (August 21): Introduction

Course overview: the great economic transformation of the twentieth century and the central questions we will pursue.

Week 2 (August 24): Origins of Capitalism and Modern Economic Growth

Why did sustained economic growth begin in Western Europe? What were its preconditions?

Readings:

- Koyama and Rubin, *How the World Became Rich*, chapters 1–3.

Week 3 (August 31): The First Age of Globalization

What drove the integration of the world economy before 1914? Who benefited and who lost?

Readings:

- Koyama and Rubin, *How the World Became Rich*, chapter 10.
- DeLong, *Slouching Towards Utopia*, chapters 1-2.

Week 4 (September 7): World War I

How did the war destroy the pre-1914 economic order? What were its long-run economic consequences?

Readings:

- Stephen Broadberry and Mark Harrison, eds., “The Economics of the Great War: A Centennial Perspective.”
- Jari Eloranta and Mark Harrison, “War and Disintegration, 1914–1950.”
- DeLong, *Slouching Towards Utopia*, chapter 5.

Week 5 (September 14): Socialism and Communism

What was the intellectual appeal of socialism? How did the Bolsheviks seize power and what kind of economy did they build?

Readings:

- *V.I. Lenin, *The April Theses* (1917).
- *V.I. Lenin, The Hanging Order Telegram (1918).
- DeLong, *Slouching Towards Utopia*, chapter 8.

Week 6 (September 21): Fascism

What was the economic program of fascism? How did fascist regimes differ from communist ones?

Readings:

- *Benito Mussolini, *The Doctrine of Fascism* (1932).
- *The Fascist Manifesto (1919).
- DeLong, *Slouching Towards Utopia*, chapter 9.

Week 7 (September 28): The Great Depression

What caused the Great Depression and why was it so severe? How did governments respond?

Readings:

- Christina D. Romer, “The Nation in Depression,” *Journal of Economic Perspectives* 7, no. 2 (1993): 19–39. <https://www.aeaweb.org/articles?id=10.1257/jep.7.2.19>

Week 8 (October 5): Midterm Examination

In-class written exam covering Weeks 1–7.

Week 9 (October 12): Soviet Communism

Did Soviet central planning “work”? What were its achievements and failures?

Readings:

- Paul R. Gregory and Mark Harrison, “Allocation under Dictatorship: Research in Stalin’s Archives” (2005).
- Natalya Naumenko, “The Political Economy of Famine: The Ukrainian Famine of 1933.”

Part II: War, Recovery, and the Keynesian Consensus

Week 10 (October 19): The Nazi Economy

How did Nazi economic policy relate to rearmament and war? Was the wartime economy efficient?

Readings:

- Adam Tooze, *The Wages of Destruction*, chapters 1 and 5.

Week 11 (October 26): World War II and the Post-War Economic Order

How did the war reshape the global economy? What institutions underpinned the postwar boom?

Readings:

- Adam Tooze, *The Wages of Destruction*, WW2 chapters.
- Nicholas Crafts and Gianni Toniolo, “Postwar Growth: An Overview.”
- Robert Higgs, “Wartime Prosperity? A Reassessment of the U.S. Economy in the 1940s” (1992).

Week 12 (November 2): The Problem of the “Third World”

Why did the developing world fail to converge? What was the role of development economics and foreign aid?

Readings:

- Koyama and Rubin, *How the World Became Rich*, chapter 10.

Week 13 (November 9): Inflation and the Collapse of the Keynesian Consensus

What caused the Great Inflation? How did it undermine the postwar policy framework?

Readings:

- *Milton Friedman, “The Role of Monetary Policy,” *American Economic Review* 58, no. 1 (1968): 1–17.

- J. Bradford DeLong, “America’s Peacetime Inflation: The 1970s” (1997).

Part III: Neoliberalism, Globalization, and Their Discontents

Week 14 (November 16): The “Neoliberal” Economic Order

What policies did Reagan and Thatcher actually pursue? Were welfare states dismantled or merely reformed?

Readings:

- William Easterly, “In Search of Reforms for Growth.”
- David Autor, David Dorn, and Gordon Hanson, “The China Syndrome: Local Labor Market Effects of Import Competition in the United States” (2013).

Thanksgiving Break (November 23–27) — No Class

Week 15 (November 30): Student Presentations

Student presentations and course review.

Final Examination Period: Review, student presentations, and final exam. Date TBD.

Primary Source Readings

Key primary sources assigned for discussion (marked with * above):

- **Lenin:** *What Is to Be Done?*, *State and Revolution*, *The April Theses*, The Hanging Order Telegram
- **Mussolini:** *The Doctrine of Fascism* (1932), The Fascist Manifesto (1919)
- **Friedman:** “The Role of Monetary Policy” (1968)

Books for Presentation Assignments

- Milton Friedman and Anna J. Schwartz, *A Monetary History of the United States, 1867–1960* (1963)
- Adam Tooze, *The Deluge* (2014)
- Liaquat Ahamed, *Lords of Finance* (2010)
- Phillips O’Brien, *How the War Was Won* (2015)
- Robert Gordon, *The Rise and Fall of American Growth* (2016)
- Jennifer Burns, *Milton Friedman: The Last Conservative* (2023)
- Daniel Stedman Jones, *Masters of the Universe* (2012)
- Angus Burgin, *The Great Persuasion* (2012)

IV. Grading Scale and Rubrics

Grading Scale

A	94–100%	B	84–86%	C	74–76%
A-	90–93%	B-	80–83%	C-	70–73%
B+	87–89%	C+	77–79%	D	60–69%
				E	Below 60%

Participation Rubric

A	Student is always prepared, regularly contributes to discussion in a meaningful way, and demonstrates engagement with the readings.
B	Student is usually prepared and contributes to discussion regularly.
C	Student is sometimes prepared and occasionally contributes to discussion.
D	Student is rarely prepared and seldom contributes.
E	Student does not participate or is frequently absent.

Examination Rubric: Essays and Short Answers

	Complete	Analysis	Evidence	Writing
A	Fully addresses all parts of the question	Demonstrates sophisticated analytical reasoning	Draws on specific, relevant evidence from readings and lectures	Clear, well-organized prose
B	Addresses most parts of the question	Demonstrates solid analytical reasoning	Uses relevant evidence but with some gaps	Generally clear writing
C	Addresses the question partially	Analysis is present but underdeveloped	Limited use of evidence	Adequate but unpolished
D	Minimally addresses the question	Little analytical reasoning	Little or no evidence	Poorly organized
E	Does not address the question	No analysis	No evidence	Incoherent

Writing Rubric

	Thesis & Argumentation	Use of Sources	Organization	Grammar & Style
A	Clear, original thesis; well-structured argument throughout	Sources integrated effectively and cited properly	Logical structure with smooth transitions	Near error-free; sophisticated style
B	Clear thesis; argument generally well-developed	Good use of sources with minor citation issues	Clear structure with occasional rough transitions	Few errors; competent style
C	Thesis present but vague; argument under-developed	Some use of sources; citation errors	Adequate structure but unclear in places	Noticeable errors; basic style
D	No clear thesis; weak argument	Minimal use of sources	Poor organization	Frequent errors
E	No thesis or argument	No sources used	No discernible organization	Pervasive errors

V. Required Policies

Laptops and Electronic Devices

Laptops, tablets, and phones are to remain closed and put away during class. Research consistently finds that longhand note-taking improves comprehension and retention relative to typing, and that open screens distract both their users and the students around them. To support this, my detailed PDF slides will be posted to Canvas before each class meeting, so there is no need to transcribe material in real time. Students are encouraged to bring printed slides if they wish and to take notes by hand.

Students who require a laptop or other electronic device for medical or disability-related reasons will, of course, have those accommodations honored. Please provide the relevant documentation through the Disability Resource Center and discuss your needs with me at the start of the semester.

Attendance Policy

Requirements for class attendance and make-up exams, assignments, and other work in this course are consistent with university policies. For more information, consult the university attendance policies.

Students Requiring Accommodation

Students with disabilities who experience learning barriers and would like to request academic accommodations should connect with the Disability Resource Center. It is important for students to share their accommodation letter with their instructor and discuss their access needs as early as possible in the semester.

UF Evaluations Process

Students are expected to provide professional and respectful feedback on the quality of instruction in this course by completing course evaluations online via GatorEvals.

Additional Academic Policies and Resources

For additional information on university academic policies and resources, visit <https://go.ufl.edu/syllabuspolicies>.